Motionholic

INDUSTRY RESEARCH REPORT · OCTOBER 2026

The Marketing Agency Industry Problems and Content Solutions

What marketing agencies are struggling with right now, and what to publish, produce and measure to fix it. 11 problems, 33 solutions.

Prepared by Motionholic · motionholic.com

NAVIGATION

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OVERVIEW

Executive Summary

Marketing demand is healthy, but agencies are not capturing it. Worldwide ad spend grew 8.6% in 2025 while holding-company revenue fell 1.2%. Platforms, in-house teams and AI are absorbing routine execution, and the billable hour turns every AI productivity gain into lost revenue. This report maps the eleven problems that matter most in 2026, backs each with current data, and offers three practical solutions for each, every one paired with a specific content play.



Chart: the global agency sector is projected to grow from USD 473.6 billion in 2026 to USD 591.6 billion in 2031 (MaxPlaces). Growth is moderate and unevenly shared.

What the data says

- **AI is a structural threat and an opportunity.** 53% of agency owners see it as a serious threat, yet the strongest-margin agencies combine AI with labor optimization.
- **Profit, not revenue, is the problem.** 21.5% of sampled agencies lose money and the average expected 2026 operating margin is 13.3%.
- **Search and measurement are breaking at the same time.** 64% cite AI Overviews as a top concern and 55% of clients ask how marketing connects to revenue.
- **Relationships are fragile.** Retainer churn is 18%, project churn 42%, and in-housing of PPC reached 73% commitment among in-house teams.
- **People are the constraint.** Agency turnover is about 30% against an 18% all-industry average, and pitch stress is pushing talent toward the exit.
- **Content is the common thread.** Every problem has a content-led solution, and short-form video is the top-ROI format for the largest share of marketers.

HOW TO READ THIS REPORT

Each problem section has two pages: the evidence (key figures, context and charts), then three solutions. Every solution has a plain description and a specific content play. A short quick win closes each section. Sources are numbered and listed at the end.

OVERVIEW

The Eleven Problems at a Glance

01
AI is compressing agency work
Clients now test AI as a replacement, not just a tool

02
Margins are shrinking
Revenue is growing, profit is not keeping up

03
The billable hour no longer works
AI makes faster delivery a revenue loss under time-based pricing

04
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Rankings can hold steady while clicks disappear

05
Proving ROI and attribution is getting harder
Clients ask 'what did it do for revenue?' and the data is fragmenting

06
Client churn, trust gaps and in-housing
Relationships are won in pitches and lost in the first 90 days

07
Winning new business is slow and expensive
Pitches are costly, win rates are low, and spec work is widespread

08
Talent turnover and burnout
The people who deliver the work are the first to leave

09
Operational overload: scope creep, tool sprawl and rising expectations
More tools and more asks, with the same number of hours

10
AI slop and the content quality squeeze
Demand for video and short-form volume is rising, and trust is fragile

11
Privacy, consent and signal loss
Compliance is accumulating even though third-party cookies survived

12
What it means for video-led agencies
Read-through and 90-day roadmap

Problems 1 to 3 are about the business model (value, margin, pricing). Problems 4 to 6 are about demand and proof (search, attribution, retention). Problems 7 to 9 are about the engine room (acquisition, people, operations). Problems 10 and 11 are about the content itself and the data rules around it.

PROBLEM 1 OF 11

01

AI is compressing agency work

Clients now test AI as a replacement, not just a tool

KEY FIGURES

53%

of agency owners see AI as a serious threat, up from 44% a year earlier (SparkToro)

20%

of clients plan to replace some agency work with AI, versus 12% who plan to switch agencies (PPC survey)

87.3%

of agency professionals say the traditional agency model is broken or heading there (Basis)

What is happening

Agencies use AI to cut their own labor while clients use the same tools to question retainers, hourly billing and markups. Basis found that nine in ten agency professionals see AI as a threat to primary revenue streams, and the share of AI pessimists jumped from 19.9% to 32.0% in a year. Work that was already cheap to produce, such as basic copy, resizing and simple edits, is the first to be repriced. Work that depends on judgment, accountability and integration into the client's business is holding its price far better.

Agency owners who see AI as a serious threat

% of agency owners. Source: SparkToro State of Digital Agencies (as cited, 2026)



Sources: [3], [10], [8], [32] (see Sources page)

AI IS COMPRESSING AGENCY WORK

Solutions for Problem 1

1

Sell judgment and accountability, not labor

Repackage services around decisions the client cannot automate: positioning, offer design, creative direction and channel strategy. Price the decision and the result, and let AI lower your delivery cost behind the scenes.

CONTENT PLAY

Publish a recurring 'how we decide' series: short videos and LinkedIn posts that show the reasoning behind a real creative or channel choice, including what you rejected and why.

2

Turn your process into proprietary IP

Name your frameworks, scorecards and playbooks so the client buys a system, not hours. A named method is harder to replace with a prompt and easier to defend in a pricing conversation.

CONTENT PLAY

Create a flagship case study video per framework: problem, method, measurable outcome. Add a downloadable one-page version for sales conversations.

3

Specialize in a niche and own its conversation

Industry surveys describe polarisation: clearly positioned specialists gain momentum while generalists face pricing and positioning pressure. Pick one or two niches and become the obvious expert.

CONTENT PLAY

Run one niche content hub: a weekly short-form series, a monthly teardown of niche brands' content, and a niche-specific landing page for every service.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Sell judgment and accountability, not labor	Low	30 days
2. Turn your process into proprietary IP	Medium	3-6 months
3. Specialize in a niche and own its conversation	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: audit your service menu. Mark each line as 'commodity' (AI can do most of it) or 'judgment' (a human is accountable), and move your sales messaging toward the second group.

PROBLEM 2 OF 11

02

Margins are shrinking

Revenue is growing, profit is not keeping up

KEY FIGURES

13.3%

average agency operating margin expected for 2026, down from a hoped-for 14% (Marketing Services Outlook)

21.5%

of agencies in a 186-agency sample are losing money, up from 13% the previous year (Planable)

0

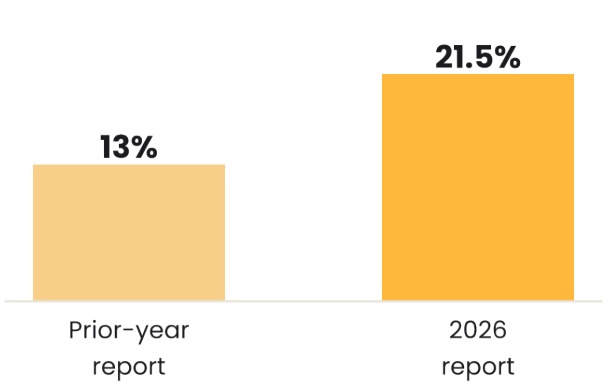
loss-making agencies among those combining AI optimization with labor optimization and no reliance on price rises (Planable)

What is happening

Growth is harder won and increasingly fails to convert into profit. Rising costs and constrained pricing squeeze the margin from both sides. Planable's data points to client count as an early predictor: more than half of one-client agencies lose money, versus 6.5% of agencies with 20 or more clients. Price increases were more common among low-profit agencies, suggesting they react to margin pressure rather than prevent it.

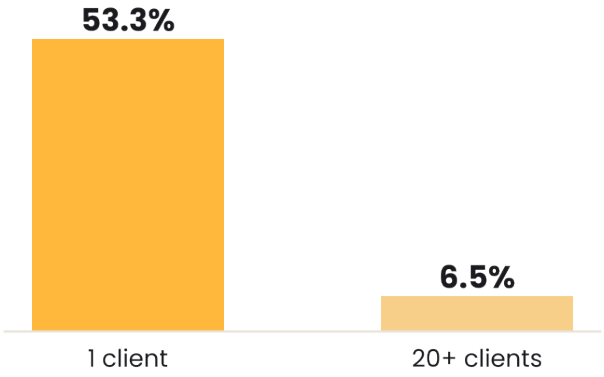
Agencies losing money

% of 186 agencies. Source: Planable 2026 Agency Profitability Report



Loss rate by client count

% of agencies losing money. Source: Planable 2026



Sources: [6], [7] (see Sources page)

MARGINS ARE SHRINKING

Solutions for Problem 2

1

Build for leverage with repeatable delivery

Standardize briefs, templates, review steps and handoffs so each extra client costs less to serve than the last. The healthier agencies in the data add leverage, not complexity.

CONTENT PLAY

Atomize content: record one long-form flagship asset (a podcast, webinar or talk) and cut it into 10 to 20 short clips, quotes and carousels with a fixed production checklist.

2

Broaden the client base beyond a handful of accounts

Concentration is a margin risk. Aim for a portfolio where losing one client is an inconvenience, not a crisis, using lower-touch entry offers to feed the base.

CONTENT PLAY

Always-on lead magnets (a benchmark, a template pack, a short course) with an email nurture sequence so new inquiries arrive without a pitch each time.

3

Pair AI optimization with labor optimization, not price rises alone

Use AI for first drafts, rough cuts and data prep while humans own quality and strategy. Re-deploy the saved hours into higher-value work instead of simply cutting price or headcount.

CONTENT PLAY

Document a content production pipeline (brief, AI-assisted draft, human edit, QA, publish) and track cost per finished asset monthly.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Build for leverage with repeatable delivery	Medium	60-90 days
2. Broaden the client base beyond a handful of accounts	Medium	3-6 months
3. Pair AI optimization with labor optimization, not price rises alone	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: calculate your real margin per client including hours spent on revisions, meetings and reporting. Retire or reprice the bottom 20% of accounts.

PROBLEM 3 OF 11

03

The billable hour no longer works

AI makes faster delivery a revenue loss under time-based pricing

KEY FIGURES

28%

of agencies still use hourly billing as their standard pricing (Ignition survey)

78%

use retainers as a primary model, up from 64% in 2023 (Digital Agency Network)

18% vs 13%

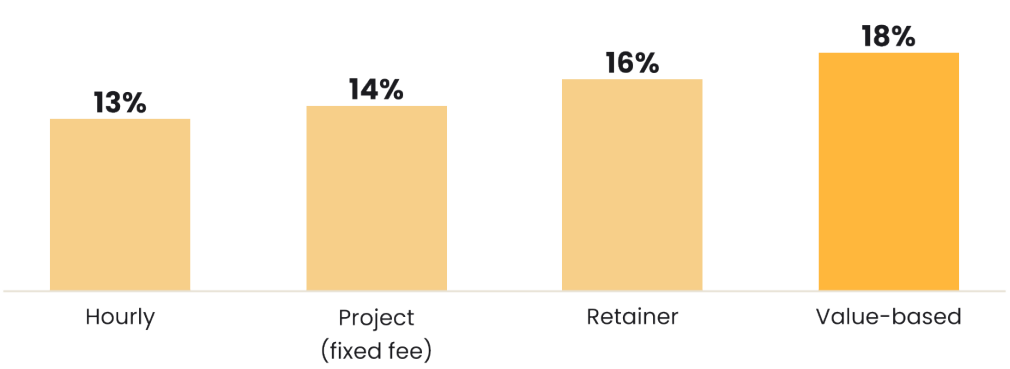
net margin for value-based versus hourly-billed agencies (Promethean Research)

What is happening

When AI shortens the time behind a deliverable, hourly billing punishes efficiency and rewards slowness. Only 20% of agencies raised rates in 2025 to 2026, down from 28% the year before, partly because clients push back on AI-era pricing. Outcome and value pricing show the strongest margins, but they demand clean measurement and confidence in articulating value. Some analysts caution that value-based pricing needs attribution clarity that many client relationships lack, so a hybrid is often the practical route.

Net margin by pricing model

Net margin %. Source: Promethean Research 2026 (via Agiled)



Sources: [11], [13], [14], [32], [34] (see Sources page)

THE BILLABLE HOUR NO LONGER WORKS

Solutions for Problem 3

1

Productize services into tiered packages

Define fixed scopes at clear price points (for example Single, Growth and Premium tiers). Clients get predictability, you get repeatable delivery and margin that improves as you get faster.

CONTENT PLAY

Publish a transparent pricing page and a short explainer video that shows exactly what each tier includes and a sample deliverable for each.

2

Hybrid retainer plus performance accelerator

Keep a base retainer for predictable cash flow and add a capped bonus tied to an outcome you can measure, such as qualified leads, booked calls or retention.

CONTENT PLAY

Co-write a one-page 'success scorecard' with each client and review it in a monthly video update so the bonus is never a surprise.

3

Value-based pricing for work with clear, measurable outcomes

Reserve it for engagements where results are attributable (a launch, a funnel rebuild, a lead-gen sprint) and keep simple time-and-materials for genuinely uncertain scope.

CONTENT PLAY

Build a case-study library with before-and-after numbers so you can price from proven value, and use it in proposals.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Productize services into tiered packages	Medium	60-90 days
2. Hybrid retainer plus performance accelerator	Medium	60-90 days
3. Value-based pricing for work with clear, measurable outcomes	High	3-6 months

QUICK WIN

This month: pick one service and relaunch it as a fixed-scope package with a written definition of 'done'.

PROBLEM 4 OF 11

04

AI search is eroding organic traffic

Rankings can hold steady while clicks disappear

KEY FIGURES

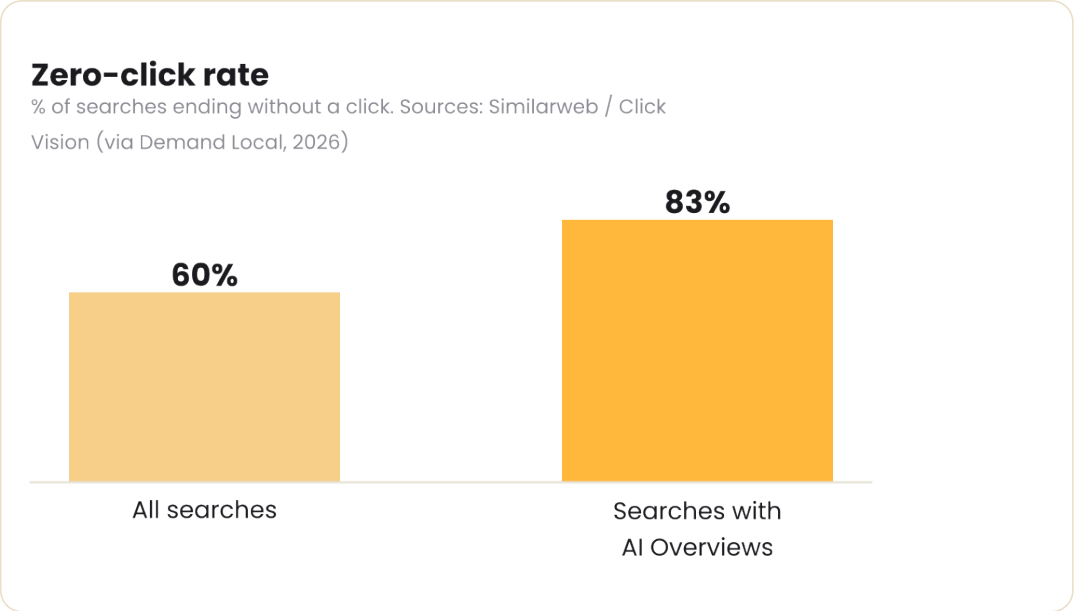
64%
of agencies name Google's AI Overviews as their top industry concern (AgencyAnalytics)

59%
say AI-driven search is disrupting traditional SEO (AgencyAnalytics)

83%
zero-click rate on queries that show an AI Overview, versus about 60% across all searches (Click Vision, Similarweb)

What is happening

Agencies managing SEO portfolios report traffic falling without a clear ranking cause. Gartner predicted a 25% decline in organic traffic in 2026, and one agency analysis describes 30 to 70 percent click drops on informational-heavy portfolios. The picture is not uniform: early 2026 data showed click-through rates stabilizing in several segments, and citation visibility is becoming as important as raw clicks. The agency risk is positioning: reports that lead with traffic charts now tell a worse story than the business reality.



Sources: [1], [15], [16], [33] (see Sources page)

AI SEARCH IS ERODING ORGANIC TRAFFIC

Solutions for Problem 4

1

Move to search-everywhere content distribution

Treat YouTube, short-form video, podcasts, LinkedIn and email as search surfaces in their own right, so visibility does not depend on one results page.

CONTENT PLAY

Turn each target keyword cluster into a video, a short, a LinkedIn post and a written guide, all pointing to the same expert voice.

2

Earn citations, not just rankings

Publish original data, named expert authors, clear definitions and structured answers that AI systems can lift and attribute. Monitor where clients appear in AI answers.

CONTENT PLAY

Create a yearly benchmark report or survey per niche, with a summary page and quotable stats designed to be cited.

3

Build owned first-party audiences

Email lists, communities and CRM-driven retargeting keep working even when searchers never click. First-party activation is the defensive play cited by agencies in this space.

CONTENT PLAY

Offer a gated insight (checklist, weekly digest, private community) and show clients the audience growth alongside traffic.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Move to search-everywhere content distribution	Medium	60-90 days
2. Earn citations, not just rankings	High	3-6 months
3. Build owned first-party audiences	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: re-baseline client SEO reports to include AI-citation presence and branded search demand, not just sessions.

PROBLEM 5 OF 11

05

Proving ROI and attribution is getting harder

Clients ask 'what did it do for revenue?' and the data is fragmenting

KEY FIGURES

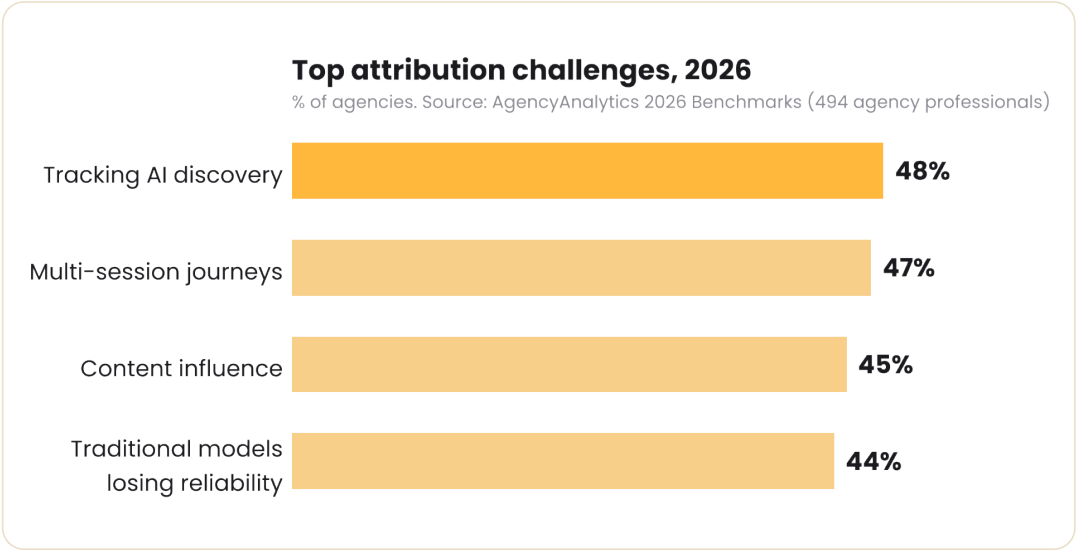
55%
of agencies say clients now regularly ask whether marketing connects to revenue, the top client question of 2026 (AgencyAnalytics)

48%
name tracking AI-driven discovery as their hardest attribution problem

33%
of marketers cite measuring ROI as their top challenge (HubSpot State of Marketing)

What is happening

Four attribution problems hit at the same time: AI discovery, multi-session journeys, content influence and traditional models losing reliability. Prospects who find a brand through ChatGPT or an AI Overview leave no clean referral trail, and much of the value of content (trust, familiarity, shortlist inclusion) never shows up in a last-click report. Agencies that cannot connect their work to revenue are exposed in every budget review.



Sources: [2], [4] (see Sources page)

PROVING ROI AND ATTRIBUTION IS GETTING HARDER

Solutions for Problem 5

1

Report from pipeline and revenue backwards

Anchor reporting in CRM data: leads, opportunities, closed revenue and payback. Show channel metrics only as supporting evidence for the revenue story.

CONTENT PLAY

Deliver a monthly five-minute video walkthrough of the client's dashboard: what happened, why, and what we will do next.

2

Add self-reported attribution

Add a required 'How did you first hear about us?' field to forms and sales calls, and log the answers. It catches AI, podcast, social and word-of-mouth discovery that tracking misses.

CONTENT PLAY

Seed memorable, searchable content hooks (a named series, a distinctive phrase) so people can recall and report where they met you.

3

Measure content influence with leading indicators

Track branded search lift, assisted conversions, direct traffic and share of voice in AI answers as a combined influence scorecard, with directional goals agreed in advance.

CONTENT PLAY

Run before-and-after tests on a single content push (a video series or report launch) and publish the learnings to the client.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Report from pipeline and revenue backwards	Medium	30 days
2. Add self-reported attribution	Low	30 days
3. Measure content influence with leading indicators	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: add the self-reported attribution question to every client's primary form and review answers in the next reporting cycle.

06

PROBLEM 6 OF 11

Client churn, trust gaps and in-housing

Relationships are won in pitches and lost in the first 90 days

KEY FIGURES

18% vs 42%

annual churn for retainer versus project clients (Everything-PR synthesis)

73%

of in-house teams are committed to keeping PPC fully internal, up from 44% two years earlier (State of PPC 2026)

$400K+

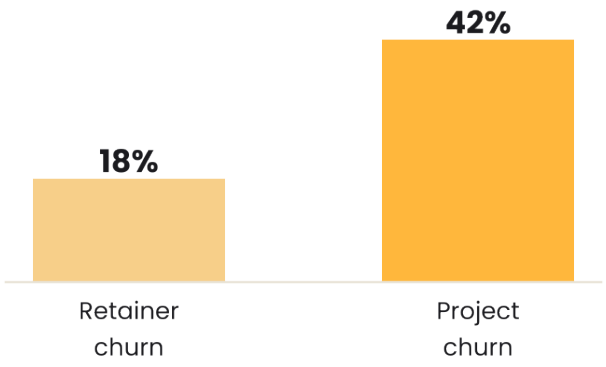
typical client-side cost of running an agency pitch, so churn is expensive for both sides (ANA/4As data via Everything-PR)

What is happening

Brands are pulling work in-house, platforms are automating execution, and clients are comparing agency fees with AI-assisted alternatives. The first 90 days are the peak risk period across engagement models. Satisfaction gaps are specific: reporting arrives on a schedule and answers questions the client did not ask, and client input and measurement issues cause friction outside the agency's direct control. Client referrals remain the number one lead source for digital agencies, so every lost relationship also shrinks the pipeline.

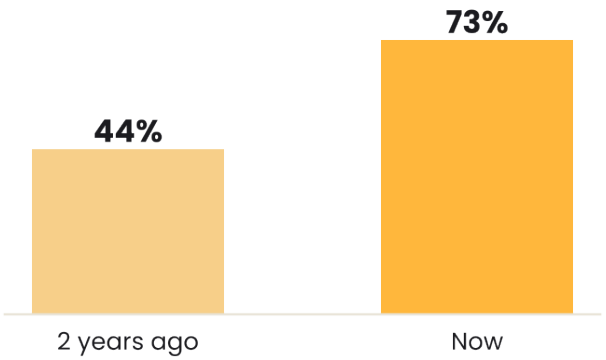
Client churn by engagement type

% annual churn. Source: Everything-PR synthesis (Sep 2026)



In-house teams keeping PPC fully inter

% of in-house teams. Source: State of PPC Global Report 2026 (via Swydo)



Sources: [8], [9], [29] (see Sources page)

CLIENT CHURN, TRUST GAPS AND IN-HOUSING

Solutions for Problem 6

1

Install 30/60/90-day health checks and proactive updates

Schedule structured check-ins in the first quarter, track a simple health score, and surface problems before the client does. Agencies with formal protocols report lower first-year churn.

CONTENT PLAY

Run a 10-part onboarding video series for new clients covering goals, approvals, tools and timelines, plus a short monthly 'what happened, what is next' video.

2

Become the embedded partner, not the replaceable vendor

Offer a hybrid model: train the client's in-house team, run the strategy and the hardest creative, and own the playbook. In-housing becomes a service you sell instead of a threat you resist.

CONTENT PLAY

Create enablement content for client teams: templates, editing guides, brand voice cheat sheets and quarterly workshops.

3

Give every client a true owner and a referral loop

Smaller rosters per account lead produce deeper ownership and quality. Happy clients then become your best acquisition channel.

CONTENT PLAY

Capture testimonial and result videos at the 90-day mark, and build a simple client-referral offer around them.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Install 30/60/90-day health checks and proactive updates	Low	30 days
2. Become the embedded partner, not the replaceable vendor	High	3-6 months
3. Give every client a true owner and a referral loop	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: book a 30-day health check for every client who started in the last six months.

07

PROBLEM 7 OF 11

Winning new business is slow and expensive

Pitches are costly, win rates are low, and spec work is widespread

KEY FIGURES

22%

average pitch win rate for agency presentations (R3 Worldwide, via SHNO)

69.6%

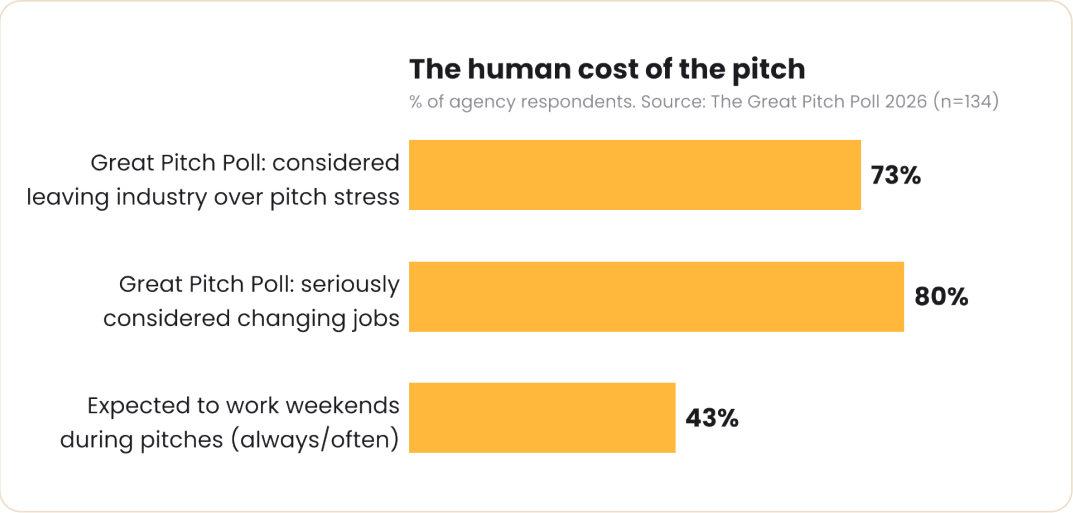
of agency respondents say new business sales is the hardest part of the pipeline (survey cited by SHNO)

83%

of agencies need one to six months to close new business (RSW/US 2024 report)

What is happening

The 4As 2026 survey reports that most agencies have win rates below 50%, with spec work and long pitch timelines raising questions about efficiency. The PRCA's Pitch Forward report found an average pitch investment above 7,000 pounds and up to 20,000 pounds, a two-to-three-month process, a one-in-three win rate, and nearly half of agencies seeing ideas used without payment. Research from Vennli shows that agencies with win rates above 50% overwhelmingly use primary research in their pitches.



Sources: [17], [18], [19], [20], [21], [30], [31] (see Sources page)

WINNING NEW BUSINESS IS SLOW AND EXPENSIVE

Solutions for Problem 7

1

Build an authority content engine that attracts inbound

Referrals lead the lead-source charts, but they are not controllable. Add inbound by publishing a point of view on your niche's specific problems and proof that you solved them.

CONTENT PLAY

A weekly niche video or LinkedIn post, a monthly case study, and a short 'proof' reel that sales can send before the first call.

2

Replace free spec pitches with paid diagnostics and quick wins

Offer a short, paid audit or a small, fast-win project. It qualifies the client, demonstrates your thinking and avoids giving away strategy for free.

CONTENT PLAY

Productize the diagnostic as a named audit with a standard deliverable and a recorded walkthrough.

3

Pitch with primary research and one-ICP pages

Show up with original insight about the prospect's market and competitors. Build one landing page per ideal customer profile instead of a generic 'we do digital' homepage.

CONTENT PLAY

Prepare a two-minute personalized video teardown of the prospect's current content before every serious call.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Build an authority content engine that attracts inbound	High	3-6 months
2. Replace free spec pitches with paid diagnostics and quick wins	Low	30 days
3. Pitch with primary research and one-ICP pages	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: set a written qualification rule (budget, fit, decision-maker) and decline pitches that fail it.

PROBLEM 8 OF 11

08

Talent turnover and burnout

The people who deliver the work are the first to leave

KEY FIGURES

30% vs 18%

annual turnover in agencies versus the all-industry average (Agiled, BLS and LinkedIn data)

73%

of adland employees have considered leaving the industry because of new-business stress (Great Pitch Poll 2026)

66%

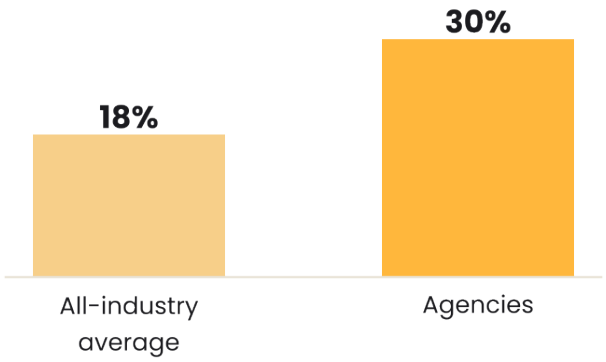
of agency owners worry junior team members will have fewer career opportunities because of AI (SparkToro, 2025)

What is happening

Agencies spend two to three times more on hiring relative to revenue than product companies, and the cost of turnover can run from 50% to 200% of salary. Utilization above 80% is cited as the number one driver of voluntary departures. Pitch pressure adds to it: 43% of respondents say they are always or often expected to work weekends during pitches. Meanwhile automation of entry-level work is eroding the traditional route from junior to senior.

Annual staff turnover

% annual turnover. Source: Agiled (BLS / LinkedIn Talent Insights)



Sources: [12], [17], [28], [10] (see Sources page)

TALENT TURNOVER AND BURNOUT

Solutions for Problem 8

1

Protect capacity: cap utilization and fix the pitch burden

Planning at 70 to 80% utilization leaves room for learning and prevents burnout. Reduce spec pitching and stagger peak workloads so the same people are not hit by both.

CONTENT PLAY

Build reusable proposal and case-study content so pitch work stops starting from zero.

2

Rebuild the career path for the AI era

Create apprenticeship-style roles where juniors learn judgment by reviewing and directing AI output, with explicit milestones to promotion.

CONTENT PLAY

Publish a career ladder and a quarterly skills curriculum, and share it publicly as employer-brand content.

3

Offer flexibility and competitive pay

Flexible work and top-quartile compensation are associated with materially lower quit rates, and are cheaper than the replacement cost.

CONTENT PLAY

Run a behind-the-scenes content series (day in the life, team spotlights, client wins) that attracts hires and makes the team visible.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Protect capacity: cap utilization and fix the pitch burden	Low	30 days
2. Rebuild the career path for the AI era	High	3-6 months
3. Offer flexibility and competitive pay	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: track utilization per person weekly and escalate anyone sustained above 85%.

PROBLEM 9 OF 11

09

Operational overload: scope creep, tool sprawl and rising expectations

More tools and more asks, with the same number of hours

KEY FIGURES

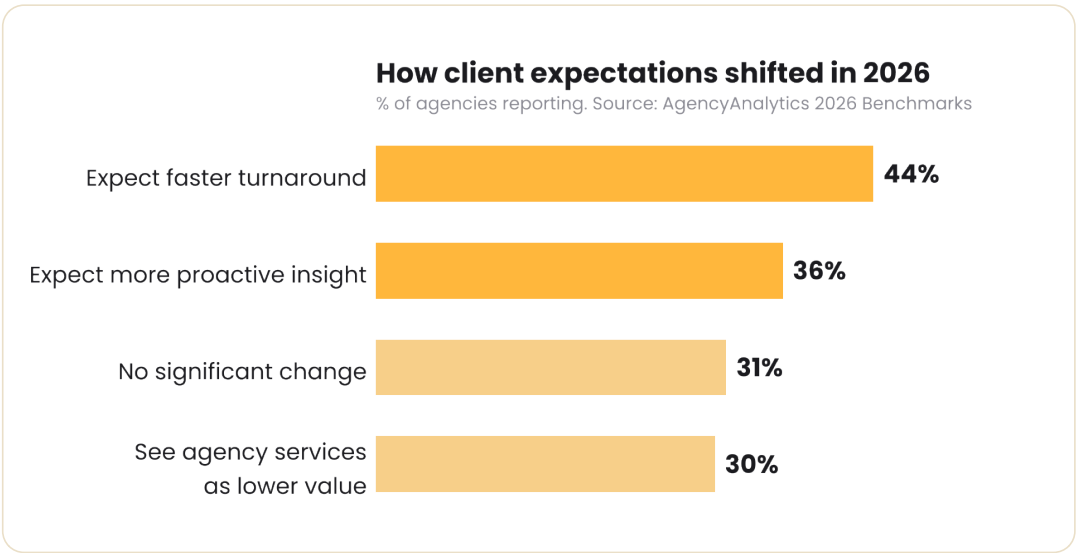
70%
of agency professionals say their jobs are harder than two years ago (Basis)

54%
say client tensions have increased over the same period (Basis)

44%
of agencies report clients now expect faster turnaround times (AgencyAnalytics)

What is happening

Expectations are rising on speed and proactivity while 30% of agencies say clients perceive their services as lower value. Scope creep eats margin quietly: small unlogged requests accumulate until a fully utilized agency still misses its profit target. Tool sprawl adds an invisible management layer, with approvals in chat, tasks in a project tool and data repaired by hand before every report.



Sources: [1], [3], [26], [27] (see Sources page)

OPERATIONAL OVERLOAD: SCOPE CREEP, TOOL SPRAWL AND RISING EXPECTATIONS

Solutions for Problem 9

1

Make scope visible with intake and change orders

Put scope in writing per client, route all requests through one intake, and quote anything outside scope as a change order before work starts.

CONTENT PLAY

Create a client handbook and a short onboarding video explaining how requests, revisions and approvals work.

2

Consolidate to a clear source of truth

Give each tool one job and name an owner. Evaluate the full handoff between sales, delivery and reporting, not the time saved inside one app.

CONTENT PLAY

Standardize content ops: briefs, editorial calendar, asset library and an approval workflow in one place.

3

Add automated scope and quality checks

Use AI to flag requests as in scope, likely extra scope or needing review, and to draft the change order, while a human stays in control of the client conversation.

CONTENT PLAY

Track cumulative scope additions by client and service monthly, and use the data in renewal and repricing conversations.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Make scope visible with intake and change orders	Low	30 days
2. Consolidate to a clear source of truth	Medium	60-90 days
3. Add automated scope and quality checks	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: choose your three noisiest clients and audit contracted scope against the work delivered in the last 60 days.

PROBLEM 10 OF 11

10

AI slop and the content quality squeeze

Demand for video and short-form volume is rising, and trust is fragile

KEY FIGURES

49%
of marketers rank short-form video the number one ROI content format (HubSpot 2026)

82%
of video marketers report a good ROI, down from a 2025 peak of 93% (Wyzowl)

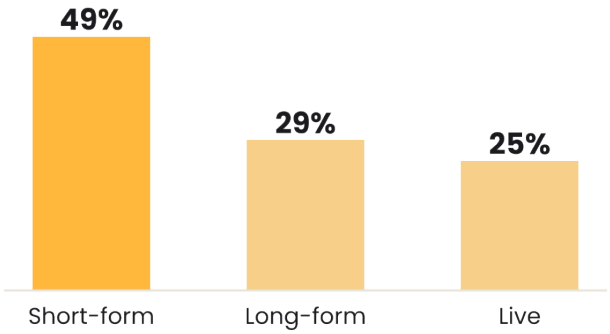
64%
of surveyed agencies name AI slop as their top AI concern (Duda survey, 36 customers)

What is happening

Short-form video is the most used format and delivers the highest ROI for the largest share of marketers, but it requires more production volume, not less, and platform-native versions for each channel. At the same time, 63% of video marketers have used AI tools to create or edit video and satisfaction with ROI slipped year over year. The result is a quality squeeze: clients want more content, faster, and are more sensitive than ever to generic, machine-flavoured output. The Duda sample is small (36), so treat that figure as directional.

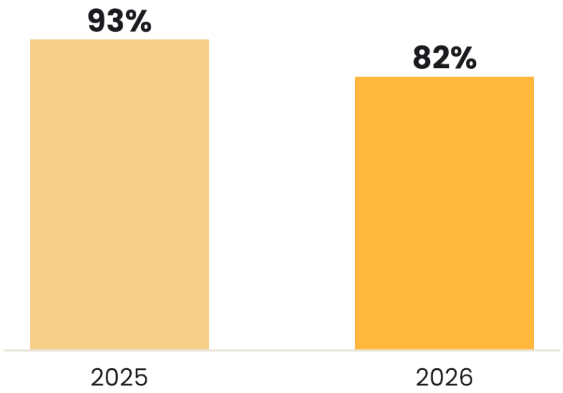
Highest-ROI video format

% of marketers naming it #1. Source: HubSpot State of Marketing 2026 (via Rocketium / PostEverywhere)



Video marketers reporting good ROI

% of video marketers. Source: Wyzowl



Sources: [22], [23], [24] (see Sources page)

AI SLOP AND THE CONTENT QUALITY SQUEEZE

Solutions for Problem 10

1

Add human quality gates to an AI-assisted workflow

Use AI for speed in rough cuts, transcripts and variations, and require a human editor, a style guide and a final QA pass before anything ships.

CONTENT PLAY

Maintain a brand voice and motion style guide per client, with approved and rejected examples.

2

Systemize volume with platform-native variants

Plan content in batches: one shoot, many cuts. Format each version for its platform (vertical, captions, pacing) rather than posting one repurposed file.

CONTENT PLAY

Build a monthly content batch calendar: flagship video, 8 to 20 shorts, clips and a quote set, with 48-hour turnaround targets.

3

Lead with proof and original perspective

Content that shows real people, real footage, original data and a clear opinion stands out in a feed full of generic output.

CONTENT PLAY

Shift the mix toward founder-led, customer-story and behind-the-scenes content with strong hooks and captions.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Add human quality gates to an AI-assisted workflow	Low	30 days
2. Systemize volume with platform-native variants	Medium	60-90 days
3. Lead with proof and original perspective	Medium	60-90 days

QUICK WIN

This month: define a 'minimum quality bar' checklist (hook, captions, sound, brand fit) and apply it to every deliverable.

11

PROBLEM 11 OF 11

Privacy, consent and signal loss

Compliance is accumulating even though third-party cookies survived

KEY FIGURES

Consent Mode v2

remains mandatory for EU and EEA ad measurement in Google products (The Ad Spend, 2026)

Oct 2025

Google retired the Privacy Sandbox and kept third-party cookies in Chrome (The Ad Spend)

Jan 2026

Meta removed 7-day and 28-day view windows from its Insights API (The Ad Spend)

What is happening

Third-party cookies survived in Chrome, but Safari and Firefox have blocked them for years, US state privacy laws keep multiplying and platform signal restrictions keep tightening. Measurement that relied on user-level tracking is less complete, which feeds directly into the attribution problem. First-party data strategies built during the cookie scare remain the correct investment.

Sources: [25] (see Sources page)

PRIVACY, CONSENT AND SIGNAL LOSS

Solutions for Problem 11

1

Collect first-party data through value-exchange content

Give people a reason to share an email or preference: a useful template, a benchmark, a quiz or a private community. Collect only what you need and disclose clearly.

CONTENT PLAY

Build a small 'content upgrade' for each top-performing page and a welcome email sequence that continues the story.

2

Adopt consent-aware, server-side measurement

Implement consent management and platform features that use hashed first-party data (for example enhanced conversions) so conversions can still be matched without relying on third-party cookies.

CONTENT PLAY

Publish a plain-language privacy and data page; trust content can be a differentiator for clients and their customers.

3

Reach audiences through contextual and creator-led channels

Contextual placements, creator partnerships and organic distribution do not depend on tracking individuals, and build brand demand that shows up in branded search and direct traffic.

CONTENT PLAY

Brief creators with a clear story and test two or three creative angles per quarter.

COMPARE THE OPTIONS (OUR ASSESSMENT)

Option	Effort	Time to first result
1. Collect first-party data through value-exchange content	Medium	60-90 days
2. Adopt consent-aware, server-side measurement	High	60-90 days
3. Reach audiences through contextual and creator-led channels	Medium	3-6 months

QUICK WIN

This month: review each client's consent banner and tag setup and confirm which conversions are still being matched.

APPENDIX

All 33 Solutions at a Glance

Problem	Solution 1	Solution 2	Solution 3
1. AI is compressing agency work	Sell judgment and accountability, not labor	Turn your process into proprietary IP	Specialize in a niche and own its conversation
2. Margins are shrinking	Build for leverage with repeatable delivery	Broaden the client base beyond a handful of accounts	Pair AI optimization with labor optimization, not price rises alone
3. The billable hour no longer works	Productize services into tiered packages	Hybrid retainer plus performance accelerator	Value-based pricing for work with clear, measurable outcomes
4. AI search is eroding organic traffic	Move to search-everywhere content distribution	Earn citations, not just rankings	Build owned first-party audiences
5. Proving ROI and attribution is getting harder	Report from pipeline and revenue backwards	Add self-reported attribution	Measure content influence with leading indicators
6. Client churn, trust gaps and in-housing	Install 30/60/90-day health checks and proactive updates	Become the embedded partner, not the replaceable vendor	Give every client a true owner and a referral loop
7. Winning new business is slow and expensive	Build an authority content engine that attracts inbound	Replace free spec pitches with paid diagnostics and quick wins	Pitch with primary research and one-ICP pages
8. Talent turnover and burnout	Protect capacity: cap utilization and fix the pitch burden	Rebuild the career path for the AI era	Offer flexibility and competitive pay
9. Operational overload: scope creep, tool sprawl and rising expectations	Make scope visible with intake and change orders	Consolidate to a clear source of truth	Add automated scope and quality checks
10. AI slop and the content quality squeeze	Add human quality gates to an AI-assisted workflow	Systemize volume with platform-native variants	Lead with proof and original perspective
11. Privacy, consent and signal loss	Collect first-party data through value-exchange content	Adopt consent-aware, server-side measurement	Reach audiences through contextual and creator-led channels

READ-THROUGH

What This Means for Video-Led Agencies

These points are our interpretation of the evidence above, not findings from the cited surveys. They show where a video editing and motion design partner can help agencies solve the problems in this report.

1

Short-form demand is rising and so is the quality bar

Short-form video is the top-ROI format for the largest share of marketers and needs platform-native volume. Agencies that cannot produce quickly at high quality need a specialist video partner.

CONTENT PLAY

Offer a batch short-form pipeline: one shoot, 8 to 20 platform-native cuts per month, with a 48-hour first-draft target.

2

Agencies are squeezed on delivery cost

With margins under pressure and talent turnover high, outsourcing repeatable editing and motion work to a dedicated team converts a fixed cost into a variable one.

CONTENT PLAY

Position the editing team as a flexible extension of the agency: month-to-month plans, no long contract, unlimited revisions.

3

Content is the answer to several problems at once

AI search, attribution, new-business acquisition and churn all have content-led fixes. Video explainers, monthly report videos and case-study reels are the common thread.

CONTENT PLAY

Build reusable templates (explainer, monthly report video, case-study reel) that agencies can drop client numbers into.

4

Trust and proof beat generic output

Concern about low-quality AI output means human-edited, branded and story-led video has a premium position.

CONTENT PLAY

Show before-and-after reels that demonstrate brand fit, sound design and pacing, not just output volume.

5

Productized pricing matches how agencies now buy

Tiered, fixed-scope per-video plans fit the move away from the billable hour and make costs predictable for agency partners.

CONTENT PLAY

Publish clear single-video, growth and premium tiers with a defined scope and a sample deliverable for each.

ACTION PLAN

A 90-Day Roadmap for Agencies

The quick wins from every section, sequenced so each phase builds on the last. Adapt the order to your own client mix.

DAYS 1 TO 30

Stabilize and measure

- Audit services into commodity versus judgment work
- Calculate true margin per client; flag the bottom 20%
- Add self-reported attribution to every client form
- Book 30-day health checks for newer clients
- Define a minimum content quality bar

DAYS 31 TO 60

Package and position

- Relaunch one service as a fixed-scope package
- Choose a niche and publish the first four pieces of a weekly series
- Introduce scope intake and change orders
- Cap utilization and plan pitch workload
- Draft a paid diagnostic to replace spec pitches

DAYS 61 TO 90

Scale the system

- Launch the monthly video report for every client
- Publish a niche benchmark or original data piece
- Pilot a hybrid retainer with a performance accelerator
- Roll out the batch content calendar and platform variants
- Review consent and measurement setup across accounts

HOW TO MEASURE PROGRESS

Track five numbers monthly: margin per client, utilization per person, client health score, number of qualified inbound inquiries, and the share of revenue-linked reporting. If those move the right way over 90 days, the rest of the plan is working.

ACTION PLAN

30-Day Content Plan (Demo)

A sample month of content built to win more clients.

GOAL	Book 6 to 10 qualified discovery calls in 30 days. This is a sample target: set yours from your current baseline.
AUDIENCE	Decision-makers (founders, heads of marketing) in one chosen niche who already spend on marketing.
ENTRY OFFER	A low-risk first step: a free 5-minute video review or a paid 48-hour diagnostic, instead of a free spec pitch.
CHANNELS	LinkedIn (primary), short-form video, email, and one long-form video per fortnight.
HOW TO USE	Every day has an exact topic, a written hook and what to show. Where a real client result is needed, use your own and never invent figures.
CADENCE	30 days covered: 11 LinkedIn posts, 7 short videos, 2 long videos, 4 emails, 1 outreach push of 10 personal videos, 5 internal planning and review days.

FOUR CONTENT PILLARS

Insight	**Proof**	**Process**	**Offer**
Teach something useful	Results and client stories	How you work	A clear next step

THE MONTH AT A GLANCE (DAY 1 STARTS ON A MONDAY)

Mon	Tue	Wed	Thu	Fri	Sat	Sun
1 LinkedIn	**2** LinkedIn	**3** Short video	**4** Email	**5** LinkedIn	**6** Batch	**7** Review
8 LinkedIn	**9** Short video	**10** LinkedIn	**11** Long video	**12** Email	**13** Short video	**14** Review
15 LinkedIn	**16** Short video	**17** LinkedIn	**18** Long video	**19** Email	**20** Short video	**21** Review
22 LinkedIn	**23** Short video	**24** LinkedIn	**25** Email	**26** LinkedIn	**27** LinkedIn	**28** Short video
29 Outreach	**30** Review					

WEEK 1	WEEK 2	WEEK 3	WEEK 4
Foundation and authority	**Proof and trust**	**Education and insight**	**Convert**

30-DAY CONTENT PLAN

Week 1: Foundation and authority

Say clearly who you help and why you are the expert.

Day	Channel and format	Exact topic, hook and what to show	Pillar	Call to action
1 Mon	**LinkedIn text post**	**Who we work with, and who we turn down** *Hook*: "We say no to 1 in 3 enquiries. This is the exact filter we use." List 3 signs of a great-fit client (clear goal, realistic budget, a decision-maker on the call) and 3 red flags (wants guaranteed results, no tracking, picks on price only).	**Insight**	Follow for the 30-day series
2 Tue	**LinkedIn carousel (8 slides)**	**3 shifts changing how customers find businesses in 2026** *Hook*: "Your customers no longer start on page 1 of Google." Slide 2: AI answers replace blue links. Slide 3: short video is the new search. Slide 4: owned audiences (email) beat rented reach. Slides 5 to 7: one action each. Slide 8: the CTA.	**Insight**	Comment GUIDE to get the checklist
3 Wed	**Short video (30 to 45 sec)**	**Your rankings did not drop. Your clicks did.** *Hook*: "Your rankings did not drop. Your clicks did." Screen-record a search with an AI answer on top. Say: about 60% of searches end with no click, 83% when an AI Overview shows (Similarweb via Demand Local, 2026). End with the fix: answer the question first, in plain words.	**Insight**	Link in bio: free 5-minute review
4 Thu	**Email newsletter #1**	**Subject: The 30-day marketing reset (plus a free checklist)** Three bullets on what the month covers, the checklist download, and one question: what is your biggest marketing bottleneck right now?	**Process**	Reply with your answer
5 Fri	**LinkedIn process post**	**Our first 30 days with a new client, step by step** *Hook*: "Most agencies go quiet for a month after signing. Here is what we do instead." Day 1 kickoff call. Day 3 tracking audit. Day 7 first quick win live. Day 14 progress review. Day 30 one-page results report.	**Process**	DM ONBOARD for the one-pager
6 Sat	**Batch day (internal)**	**Record five short videos for week 2** Film the days 9, 13, 16, 20 and 23 scripts back to back. Reply to every comment and DM from the week.	**Ops**	None (internal)
7 Sun	**Weekly review (internal)**	**Check what worked and pick your proof** Note which post got the most saves and comments. Shortlist 3 happy clients and ask permission to share their result.	**Ops**	None (internal)

THIS WEEK'S DELIVERABLES

Ideal-client filter written, free checklist (lead magnet) ready, booking page and email list set up, five short videos batch-recorded for week 2.

30-DAY CONTENT PLAN

Week 2: Proof and trust

Show real results so prospects feel safe choosing you.

Day	Channel and format	Exact topic, hook and what to show	Pillar	Call to action
8 Mon	**LinkedIn case-study post**	**One client, one number: how we lowered cost per lead** *Hook*: "We changed one thing and the cost per lead dropped." Use your best real result from the last 90 days. Show 3 things: the number before, the number after, and the single change that caused it. Add a screenshot. Do not invent figures.	**Proof**	DM CASE for the full story
9 Tue	**Short video (15 to 30 sec)**	**Client testimonial clip** *Hook*: "Before we started, we were stuck." Ask the client one question: what was the situation before, and what changed? Cut to 20 seconds, add captions and put the result on screen as text.	**Proof**	Book a free review
10 Wed	**LinkedIn poll**	**What slows your marketing down most?** *Hook*: "Be honest: which one is it?" Options: Getting leads. Producing content. Proving results. Finding time. Comment the winner tomorrow and promise a post on it.	**Insight**	Vote and comment
11 Thu	**Long-form video (3 to 5 min)**	**Inside a real campaign: strategy, creative and numbers in 4 minutes** Screen-share four things in order: the goal, the audience, the three creatives you tested, and the results dashboard.	**Proof**	Link to booking page
12 Fri	**Email newsletter #2**	**Subject: The case study in 300 words (and one lesson you can copy)** Summarise day 8 in short paragraphs, then give one lesson the reader can apply this week.	**Proof**	Reply AUDIT for a free mini-audit
13 Sat	**Short video**	**The mistake that cost us a client month** *Hook*: "We got this wrong. Here is what it cost us." Tell it in 3 beats: what we assumed, what went wrong, the checklist we added so it cannot happen again.	**Process**	Follow for more
14 Sun	**Batch and review (internal)**	**Record week 3 and ask for testimonials** Film the days 16 and 20 scripts. Review week 2 numbers. Message two more clients for a testimonial.	**Ops**	None (internal)

THIS WEEK'S DELIVERABLES

Two case-study permissions secured, one testimonial clip, one campaign walkthrough video, social proof added to your site and profile.

30-DAY CONTENT PLAN

Week 3: Education and insight

Teach something valuable so prospects come to you already convinced.

Day	Channel and format	Exact topic, hook and what to show	Pillar	Call to action
15 Mon	**LinkedIn carousel (7 slides)**	**5 questions to ask before hiring any marketing agency** *Hook*: "Ask these 5 questions before you sign anything." 1. What exactly is in scope? 2. How will you report results? 3. Who owns the ad accounts and data? 4. How do I exit? 5. What result in 90 days counts as success?	**Insight**	Download the full checklist
16 Tue	**Short video (30 to 45 sec)**	**3 ways to get your business named in AI answers** *Hook*: "AI tools cannot recommend you if they cannot explain what you do." 1. Explain what you do in one clear sentence on your homepage. 2. Publish your own numbers or data. 3. Put a real expert name on every article.	**Insight**	Comment AI for the checklist
17 Wed	**LinkedIn teardown post**	**I reviewed a homepage in 5 minutes: 5 fixes** *Hook*: "Five minutes. Five fixes. Here is what I found." Use your own old homepage or a willing client. Number 5 arrows on a screenshot: headline clarity, one main button above the fold, proof near the top, page speed, an easy way to contact you.	**Proof**	DM your URL for a free mini-review
18 Thu	**Long-form video (8 to 10 min)**	**How to tell if your marketing is paying for itself** *Hook*: "What did marketing do for revenue last month?" Teach 4 steps: pick one revenue number, record the source of every lead (UTM plus a how did you hear about us field), build a one-page monthly report (spend, leads, closed revenue), compare month to month.	**Insight**	Download the tracking template
19 Fri	**Email newsletter #3**	**Subject: I reviewed a homepage in 5 minutes** Share the teardown from day 17 and the tracking template from day 18. One idea, one action.	**Insight**	Reply with your questions
20 Sat	**Short video (40 sec)**	**The one question that exposes bad reporting** *Hook*: "What did marketing do for revenue?" Clip the best 40 seconds of the day 18 video. Add captions and a bold first line.	**Insight**	Follow for more
21 Sun	**Batch and review (internal)**	**Cut clips and log results** Cut two more clips from the day 18 video. Write down which topics got the most replies and comments.	**Ops**	None (internal)

THIS WEEK'S DELIVERABLES

One long-form video published and cut into at least three clips, a downloadable tracking template, and a live free mini-review offer.

30-DAY CONTENT PLAN

Week 4: Convert

Make the next step obvious, easy and low-risk.

Day	Channel and format	Exact topic, hook and what to show	Pillar	Call to action
22 Mon	**LinkedIn post**	**What you get in 48 hours: our marketing diagnostic** *Hook:* "In 48 hours you will know exactly where your marketing leaks." Show a sample report page with 3 sections: the biggest funnel leak, three quick wins, a 30-day action plan.	**Offer**	Book a diagnostic
23 Tue	**Short video (30 sec)**	**Why we do not do free pitches** *Hook:* "Free pitches cost you and us. Here is what we do instead." Explain in 3 points: pitches reward the best slide deck, not the best work; they burn time on both sides; a paid diagnostic gives real answers.	**Offer**	Book a call
24 Wed	**LinkedIn carousel (6 slides)**	**Working with us: day 1, day 30, day 60, day 90** *Hook:* "Here is exactly what happens after you say yes." One slide per milestone: what we do, what you see, what you decide. Last slide: how to start.	**Process**	DM JOURNEY
25 Thu	**Email newsletter #4**	**Subject: How to start in 48 hours** Two client testimonials, what the diagnostic includes, the price, and a booking link. Keep it under 250 words.	**Offer**	Reply to book a call
26 Fri	**LinkedIn FAQ post**	**5 questions every client asks us (honest answers)** *Hook:* "You are probably wondering about the price. Here it is." Answer: price range, time to first results, contract length, who does the work, and what happens if it is not working.	**Offer**	Book a call
27 Sat	**Referral ask (post and message)**	**Know a business owner whose marketing feels stuck?** *Hook:* "Introduce us and we will give them a free 5-minute video review." Post it, then message 10 past clients and partners personally.	**Offer**	Tag or message an intro
28 Sun	**Short video (45 sec)**	**Month recap: what we published and what we learned** *Hook:* "30 days, 30 pieces of content, here is what happened." Show 3 numbers (posts published, calls booked, best post) and one lesson. End with the diagnostic offer.	**Proof**	Follow and book
29 Mon	**Outreach push**	**Send 10 personalised 2-minute video teardowns** *Hook:* "Hi (first name), I looked at your site and found one quick win." Pick 10 businesses from your day 1 ideal-client list. Video outline: 0:00 greet by name, 0:15 what you noticed, 1:15 the one fix, 1:45 offer a call.	**Offer**	Reply to book a call
30 Tue	**Month review (internal)**	**Score the month and plan the next one** Fill in the scorecard on the next page, double down on the top 3 posts, drop the weakest format, plan month 2.	**Ops**	None (internal)

THIS WEEK'S DELIVERABLES

Diagnostic offer page live, FAQ answered publicly, ten personalised outreach videos sent, month scorecard completed and next month planned.

30-DAY CONTENT PLAN

Production System and Scorecard

Make the plan sustainable, then measure whether it is bringing in clients.

One flagship asset, many pieces

Do not create 30 pieces from scratch. Record a few strong flagship assets and cut them down. This is the reuse map for the long-form video on day 18.

Output	Where it comes from
1 flagship long-form video	Day 18 video (8 to 10 min)
3 to 4 short clips	Best moments with captions (days 20, 21)
1 carousel	Key steps as 6 to 8 slides
2 text posts	One story, one lesson
1 email	Day 19 newsletter
1 downloadable	Template or checklist (lead magnet)
1 outreach asset	Short teardown sent to prospects (day 29)

A simple weekly rhythm

- **Saturday, about 2 hours:** batch-record the next week's short videos and write the captions.
- **Sunday, 30 minutes:** review the numbers, answer comments and DMs, and pick the next week's hooks.
- **Weekdays, 20 minutes a day:** publish, then reply to every comment within a few hours. Replies drive reach and conversations.
- **Every post ends with one call to action.** Never ask for two things at once.

30-day scorecard (sample targets, adjust to your baseline)

Metric	Sample target	Where to track
Qualified discovery calls booked	**6 to 10**	Calendar and CRM
Inbound DMs and keyword comments ('GUIDE', 'CASE', 'AUDIT')	**20 or more**	LinkedIn inbox
Lead-magnet downloads	**40 or more**	Email platform
Email replies from newsletters	**15 or more**	Inbox
Outreach videos sent and replied to	**10 sent, 3 replies**	Outreach log
Posts published against plan	**30 of 30 days covered**	Content calendar

DEMO NOTE

This is an illustrative plan, not a guarantee of results. Targets are examples to adjust. Results depend on your niche, offer, consistency and starting audience. Statistics used in hooks come from the report sections above and should be re-checked and attributed when you publish.

APPENDIX

Sources and Method

This report was compiled in October 2026 from publicly available surveys, vendor research and trade coverage. Sample sizes and methods differ, and several figures are reported by a vendor that sells related products, so treat them as directional rather than definitive. Where a figure comes from a small sample (for example the Duda survey of 36 customers or the Great Pitch Poll of 134 respondents) the text says so. Figures cited second-hand are attributed to the original study and to the page that reported it.

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